ENTERTAINMENT | Cinema

RRRoar: What it takes to make blockbusters. And leap across geographies

RAM CHARAN *Actor*

THE ROAR OF RAM

Actor Ram Charan came and 'Naatu Naatu'-ed his way to the hearts of the audience at the India Today Conclave. Fresh off the Oscar success for *RRR*'s (2022) peppy track, the Telugu superstar was in a jubilant mood and still processing the historic moment—'Naatu Naatu' is now the first song from an Indian production to win an Oscar for best original song. "Naatu Naatu is no more our song, it is India's song," said the actor, as he described the arduous albeit fun 20-day schedule to craft a track that would go on to transcend geographical and linguistic boundaries.

In a nearly hour-long session, Charan reflected on his cinematic journey, and how his father, megastar Chiranjeevi, continues to be an inspiration. "Today, my dad is 67 years old and he has signed three films. He is the busiest actor right now in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. He is still rocking it," says Charan.

The actor is confident that his upcoming film, a local, or a 'matti' story as he calls it, will see global acclaim as *RRR* did. "I am very confident in what I am doing," said the actor. Going by his sharp success with *RRR*, he has every reason to be. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- On *RRR*'s success, Ram Charan says the key is to tell stories rooted to the land. Citing *Magadheera* (2009), *Lagaan* (2001), and South Korea's *Parasite* (2019), he says the "West is ready to accept somebody who is original"
- If theatrical successes post-Covid–*Pushpa* (2021), *RRR* (2022), *KGF: 2* (2022) and *Pathaan* (2023)–reveal anything, it is that the big-budget, expansive action spectacle is a genre that's drawing audiences
- There's value in being fluid as an actor as it lets directors see him/her in different roles. "Your unique style can overshadow the character you are playing," says Charan
- Talking about nepotism, Ram Charan says that family connections may help one get better chances, but it's talent that's needed to survive

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH